— A FIELD MANUAL —

The PLAYBOOK

Field notes from ceremonies that solved nothing, filed under names that should not have been printed.

ALL CASE FILES ARE FICTIONAL.

ANY RESEMBLANCE TO YOUR LAST SPRINT IS COINCIDENTAL.

INDEX OF KNOWN INCIDENTS

01 CEREMONIES | 02 ROLES & PERSONAS | 03 TOOLS & TEMPLATES | 04 FINDINGS

Chapter I. Ceremonies

Four rituals investigated.
No blockers reported.
Everything blocked.

Case No. 001 — RECURRING

The Sprint That Planned Itself

SUBJECT	Sprint Planning
SYMPTOM	**“We’ll figure out scope during the sprint.”**
DIAGNOSIS	Jira / ADO filled with vague hopes and duplicate epics. Nobody names the outcome.
RECOMMENDATION	Start with outcomes, not tickets. If nobody can state the goal, do not start the sprint.

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Case No. 002 — UNRESOLVED

The Standup That Would Not End

SUBJECT	Daily Standup
SYMPTOM	**“Yesterday I... Today I... No blockers.”**
DIAGNOSIS	Rote status ritual with no real signal. Team performs updates for the room, not the work.
RECOMMENDATION	Ask: “What would unblock the team today?” Then let people leave.

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Case No. 003 STANDING

The Retro That Solved Nothing

SUBJECT	Sprint Retrospective
SYMPTOM	**Complaints aired. Post-its written. Nothing changes by next sprint.**
DIAGNOSIS	Venting mistaken for progress. No owner assigned to any action.
RECOMMENDATION	Turn one vent into one action item every sprint. Name the owner before the meeting ends.

FILED BY THE CULT OF CLARITY END OF SPRINT

Case No. 004 IN REGRESSION

The Demo That Demoed a Prototype of a Demo

SUBJECT	Sprint Demo
SYMPTOM	**“Please imagine this is clickable.”**
DIAGNOSIS	PowerPoint pixels shown in place of shipped work. Team performs delivery.
RECOMMENDATION	Show real value or say the truth. “We did not ship this sprint” is a valid demo.

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Chapter II.

Roles & Personas

Four archetypes at large. Suspected of Agile theater in varying degrees.

Case No. 005 CONFIDENTIAL

The Voice That Forgot to Listen

SUBJECT	Product Owner
ALIAS	**“Voice of the customer.”**
DIAGNOSIS	Speaks for customers. Has not spoken to customers in six sprints.
RECOMMENDATION	Schedule the customer call. Bring transcripts. Stop paraphrasing.

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Case No. 006 SUSPECTED

The Master Who Forgot the Purpose

SUBJECT	Scrum Grandmaster
ALIAS	**“Keeper of the ceremony.”**
DIAGNOSIS	Enforces every ritual. Cannot explain why any of them exist.
RECOMMENDATION	Ask what each ceremony is for. If the answer is “the framework,” cancel it.

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Case No. 007 OPEN

The Lead Who Only Measured Delivery

SUBJECT	Delivery Lead
ALIAS	**“Gets things shipped.”**
DIAGNOSIS	Measures success only by shipping. Value shipped is not measured at all.
RECOMMENDATION	Add one outcome metric per initiative. Ship becomes shipped-and-used.

FILED BY THE CULT OF CLARITY Q4

Case No. 008 WITNESSED

The Stakeholder Who Joined Sprint Six

SUBJECT	Stakeholder X
ALIAS	**“I have a small change.”**
DIAGNOSIS	Absent through discovery. Present through re-scoping. Loud through delivery.
RECOMMENDATION	Publish the decision log. Late input is welcome; late overrides are not.

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Chapter III.

Tools & Templates

Four artifacts recovered from the scene. All still in circulation.

Case No. 009 PRESERVED

The Poster That Time Forgot

SUBJECT	Definition of Done
CONDITION	**Laminated. Last revised: pre-pandemic.**
DIAGNOSIS	Written when the team was different. Referenced by no one. Enforced by silence.
RECOMMENDATION	Rewrite it in the next refinement. Anything you do not defend, you should not display.

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Case No. 010 NEGLECTED

The Chart Nobody Read

SUBJECT	Burndown Chart
CONDITION	**Exists. Only reviewed when things go wrong.**
DIAGNOSIS	Compliance artifact. Signal after the fact.
RECOMMENDATION	Delete it or use it. If you would stop reading it tomorrow and nothing would change, that is your answer.

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Case No. 011 MISAPPLIED

The Score That Was Not a Score

SUBJECT	Velocity Metrics
CONDITION	**Used to compare team happiness. Incorrectly.**
DIAGNOSIS	Planning signal treated as performance metric. Teams inflate points to keep the number steady.
RECOMMENDATION	Use velocity for planning only. Never in a performance review. Ever.

FILED BY THE CULT OF CLARITY DASHBOARD, TV LOBBY

Case No. 012 IN PROGRESS

The Board That Never Moved

SUBJECT	Agile Board (Jira / ADO)
CONDITION	**78% of tickets in “In Progress” or “Blocked” purgatory.**
DIAGNOSIS	Board does not reflect the actual work. Standups happen anyway.
RECOMMENDATION	Jira and ADO are not the source of truth. People are. Talk to the humans before you touch the board.

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Chapter IV · Findings

The Verdict.

Twelve cases reviewed. Four truths recovered. Filed under the only category that matters.

01	Jira / ADO is not the source of truth. PEOPLE ARE. If the board does not reflect reality, talk to the humans.
02	Velocity is not a performance metric. IT IS A PLANNING SIGNAL, NOT A SCOREBOARD.
03	You do not need more process. YOU NEED MORE COURAGE. Courage to speak clearly, say no, and show up human.
04	When everyone recognizes the joke, you have found a pattern. ASK WHAT KEEPS IT ALIVE.

CHAPTER V · CLOSE OF FILE

Twelve cases.
One standard.

The Playbook does not exist to make Agile prettier. It exists to help teams name the pattern before the pattern becomes culture.

Read the Manifesto and acknowledge receipt at fragileframework.com

Legal status: ceremonial. Emotional accuracy: unfortunately high.